

Nandigram, Singur, Kalinga Nagar, Lohandiguda and Polavaram among other places.

Outside Abujmarh, in the villages of Dhurli and Bhansi, SEZ has become a dirty word. The Chhattisgarh Government has sanctioned 1,500 acres of land for an Essar Steel project but residents are restive. "We can't compromise on this. We don't want compensation or to be moved to any rehabilitation camp," Ingaram Khunjam says. The middle aged man from Dhurli would prefer to stay a farmer. Essar executives accompanied by officials from the Dantewada district magistrate's office had offered to buy his land at a price

MEMORIAL: A check post in honour of the dead

higher than the market value but Khunjam declined. The scene is not much different in adjoining Bhansi where a majority of villagers are post-Partition refugees from tribal areas of Bangladesh. Short-term resettlement and rehabilitation policies of the central and state governments have built little confidence amongst the tribals.

The extremists first entered Dandakaranya—the enormous forest between Andhra Pradesh, Orissa, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra—in the 1980s and rallied for the peasants. As the sub-rural revolutionaries fantasised about a classless society, they distributed pamphlets and organised meetings to build their constituencies. Armed platoons that would

seize weapons from isolated police stations soon surfaced. As the weaponry increased, safe houses in Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Andhra Pradesh sprung up to store AK-47s, SLRS, INSAS, .303s, 12 bore rifles, and hand grenades. Landmines, improvised explosive devices and rocket launchers were assembled at fabrication units in cities. A military commission with region specific commands was set up to lay the foundations of the people's government in Dandakaranya. The new democratic revolution was boosted by help from the London-based far Left platform, Revolutionary Internationalist Movement. Maoists from the subcontinent chipped in through the Coordination Committee of Maoist Parties and Organisations of South Asia (CCOMPOSA). Nepali Maoists were an important link till they joined the political mainstream. The compact revolutionary zone or red corridor from Pashupati to Tirupati was conceived by CCOMPOSA.

In response to the growing clout of the Maoists in the wilderness of Chhattisgarh, the Government launched Operation Peace or Salwa Judum. The idea was conceived by communist renegade and state Congress chief Mahendra Karma in Bijapur in June 2005. Chief Minister Raman Singh quickly embraced Karma's ingenious suggestion that the Government should arm its people to fight the Maoists. In their version of vigilantism, the peace keepers of Salwa Judum were rendered three months of rifle and machine gun training by the police. Almost 60,000 people from Maoist-controlled villages shifted to 17 Salwa Judum camps throughout



Maoists have mobilised people against the Centre's SEZ policy which they think will create "neo colonial enclaves"